spoken by many tribals when they communicated with each other and with the people of the plains). As early as 1957, tribal leaders from the Lohit Frontier Division in the NEFA had submitted a memorandum to the Governor of Assam, saying that, 'Hindi may be taught to the students in the same school…[where the medium of instruction is] Assamese. It is known to your honour that in this Division seven classes of tribals are living such as Abor, Khamti, Edu, Miju, Digaru, Miri, Singpho and Tibetans. Assamese is the main language to exchange thoughts amongst ourselves.'[84] Whatever sympathy there might have been for their point of view in New Delhi in the late 1950s, there was much less of an incentive to promote Assamese language at the expense of Hindi in the NEFA after 1962.

The NEFA, previously a hill region of Assam, was converted into the Union Territory of Arunachal Pradesh in 1972 and proclaimed a state in 1987, thus becoming somewhat estranged from the plains with which the local people had had trade and other contacts for centuries. But the integration of the NEFA was more important than such local sensitivities for India's security planners. The new administrative entity was given a name in Sanskrit, meaning 'The Land of Dawn', and a new capital was established at Itanagar at the foothills of the Himalayas, close to the ruins of a fifteenth century fort built by Hindu kings from the plains.

Arunachal and the six other Indian states in the traditionally volatile northeastern region are connected with the rest of the country through a strategically sensitive corridor between Nepal, Bhutan, and Bangladesh called the Siliguri Neck, or more popularly, the Chicken's Neck, which at its narrowest point is only about 27 kilometres wide. The need to secure that area and the northeast became even more of a priority after the 1962 War. On 24 October of that year, the American ambassador John K. Galbraith had met the prime minister of Bhutan, who had told him that Chinese troops were massed on the borders of his kingdom. According to the former CIA analyst Bruce Reidel's account of the 1962 crisis, 'The miniscule army of Bhutan could not hope to stop a Chinese attack. If the Chinese broadened their offensive to include Bhutan and its even smaller neighbour Sikkim, they could easily drive south to cut off India's entire northeastern section—made up of NEFA and Assam—and link up with East Pakistan.'[85]

At the time of the 1962 War, China had no such intentions, the possibility of a move from the Chinese down to the corridor side was